

REVIEW ESSAY

(De)colonizing Early Modern Occult Philosophy

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LIANA SAIF. *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy*. Houndmills, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015. Pp. vi + 277.

The quest to marry Plato and Aristotle defined Western intellectual history in the medieval and early modern periods; and it was only theoretically and historically achieved by means of *Arabic astral magic*. So argues Liana Saif in *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy*, a recent installment in Palgrave's burgeoning Historical Studies in Witchcraft and Magic series. This study is a thoroughly revised version of the author's 2011 Birkbeck, University of London doctoral thesis; it dispenses with that study's concluding discussion of seventeenth-century European developments (material she has published separately),¹ and adds instead two chapters on the Arabic-Latin translation movement of the twelfth and thirteenth as foundation of subsequent philosophical developments in Europe. Between the Bacons, she here prefers Roger to Francis. Nevertheless, the focus of the book remains heavily early modern: Saif seeks to show the debt of a trinity of Renaissance thinkers—Marsilio Ficino, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola, and John Dee—to Arabic natural philosophy, especially astrology, and its Latin scholastic receptions.

Such a thesis is, of course, hardly new; but vanishingly few Western intellectual historians are competent Arabists and Latinists in equal measure and so in a position to substantiate it. As a consequence, the profound *Arabicness*

1. Liana Saif, "Homocentric Science in a Heliocentric Universe," in Nicholas Campion and Dorian Gieseler Greenbam, eds., *Astrology in Time and Place: Cross-Cultural Questions in the History of Astrology* (Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars, 2015), 159–72; idem, "The Arabic Theory of Astral Influences in Early Modern Medicine," *Renaissance Studies* 25 (2011): 609–26.

of early modern Latin occult philosophy is often assumed but rarely acknowledged, much less explored—making a properly comparative intellectual history of the early modern Western—that is, Islamo-Christian—world all but impossible. This study, by a competent Arabist-Latinist, synthesizes and extends the work of Charles Burnett, Richard Lemay, and David Pingree in particular to show up the persistent Eurocentrism of the field and limn the historical mechanics of that debt. For all that it serves to further undercut and retire the Warburg Interpretation of these occult-philosophical heroes of the Renaissance, emphasizing medieval-early modern scholarly continuity over rupture and eschewing a Yatesian teleology by discarding the “Scientific Revolution” altogether, Saif’s project is thus a quintessentially Warburgian one, and faithful to the spirit, if not method, of Yates.

The book is tripartite in structure—Arabic, Arabic-to-Latin, Renaissance—and its eight chapters discuss a number of representative figures and texts from each period. Saif’s treatment of the Arabic sources is comparatively brief (chapters 1–2, 9–45), and largely summarizes existing scholarship while providing occasional correctives. A larger percentage of the book, roughly a quarter, is given to the Latin reception of these Arabic texts in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries (chapters 3–4, 46–94). Nearly a full half is given to the Renaissance sage-mages Ficino, Pico, and Dee; important correctives to the current literature are here offered (chapters 5–7, 95–171). The final chapter treats of volitional causation and celestial souls and daemons as “cosmic vital agents,” themes that run like a red thread through the book (chapter 8, 172–94). As an Islamicist myself, I will give disproportionate space to the first section in my summary below for the benefit of Europeanist readers more familiar with the early modern Christian material, then detail why this book is an important intervention in current narratives of the adoption of Islamic science by the West (usually construed, wildly antihistorically, as exclusively western Europe); I will further identify remaining lacunae and suggest directions for future, non-Eurocentric research into early modern Western intellectual and cultural history.

As Saif argues, the Arabic basis for medieval and early modern Latin occult philosophy is in the first place *astrological*: it was the pressing natural-philosophical need to explain whether and how celestial bodies causally influence terrestrial ones—a doctrine asserted but not explained by Ptolemy, and flatly rejected by Neoplatonists like Plotinus—that impelled Arabic thinkers, including in the first place Abū Ma’shar Balkhī (d. 886) and his mentor al-Kindī (d. 873), to infuse Neoplatonic metaphysics with Peripatetic physics. This marriage of Plato and Aristotle then became standard in the

Islam-Christian West thereafter as the only means by which the acknowledged effectiveness of astrology, and by extension astral-natural magic, could be adequately cosmologically explained.

Most significantly, the marriage of Plato and Aristotle, first achieved in Arabic, was instrumentalized in the two parallel theoretical modes that would define early modern occult philosophy: the hermeneutic and the causal. In the first, celestial bodies serve as *signs* indicating resemblances, sympathies or correspondences to be construed, to be *read*, by the experienced cosmographer; Foucault's concept of the semiology of nature here applies. The hermeneutic approach would then give rise to the Two Books doctrine, so central to early modern occult philosophy, whereby nature became a second scripture to be interpreted using the tools of the exegete: world as (Hebrew or Arabic, hence mathematical) text. (Saif ignores the crucial importance of Neopythagoreanism to this mode, a problem I will return to below.) The causal approach, for its part, with its expressly Aristotelian framework, allowed for the *naturalization of occult forces*: celestial bodies as efficient causes of generation and corruption in their own right. But it must be emphasized that from its inception Arabic Aristotelianism was strongly Neoplatonic in tenor, as Plotinus and Proclus were received in Arabic in the guise of Aristotle—and so *soul* could be and was readily incorporated into the theory of astral causality: celestial bodies with celestial souls, astral magic as *ensoulment*. For early Arabic philosophers and their Latin heirs, in short, astral causality was in operation both physical and psychical, a principle equal parts Aristotelian and Neoplatonic; and astrology and magic were accordingly reconceptualized as a systematic, epistemologically universal means of analyzing the cosmos “in terms of signs, causes and spirits” (5).

This epochal metaphysical and natural-philosophical synthesis was achieved in a number of seminal Arabic works, all transmitted to Christian Europe in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. Chief among them is Abū Maʿshar's *Great Introduction to Astrology* (*K. al-Mudkhal al-Kabīr ilā ʿIlm Aḥkām al-Nujūm*), which was rendered into Latin guise (*Liber introductorii maioris ad scientiam judicorum astrorum*) by John of Seville in 1133. (Significantly, Abū Maʿshar was also the father of conjunction astrology, a science that would come to be heavily patronized by dynasts and messiahs throughout the Western world, and especially its Islamic subset.) The *Great Introduction* represents a philosophical watershed: where Hellenic astrological precedent explained astral agency only in theological and semiological terms, it supplied a properly natural-philosophical—that is to say, Aristotelian—justification, adding the theory of terrestrial receptivity of celestial influences. Nor is this work simply

a theoretical corrective to Hellenic astrology; therein Abū Maʿshar synthesizes a welter of Hellenic, Persian, and Indian astrological traditions to create a more coherent, complete, and hence usable system. It thus emblemizes Islam's civilizational role as not simply late antiquity's greatest heir but indeed its direct continuation and culmination—particularly with respect to occult philosophy-science.²

In developing his astrological system, Abū Maʿshar was influenced in the first place by al-Kindī, the first Arabic philosopher, who in two treatises written before the *Great Introduction* assigns celestial bodies a generative, causal role. This is especially the case in his *On Rays* (*De radiis*, aka *Theorica artium magicarum*; the original Arabic work is lost); here astral magic is theorized as an act of ensouling whereby the rays of celestial bodies are harnessed by the mage to charge an object or image constructed according to the principle of celestial-terrestrial correspondence. That is, the mage's soul may itself deploy volitional rays that become reciprocal with those arriving from the celestial sphere in order to ensoul and activate a talisman. (By the same token, al-Kindī regards animal sacrifice as the most efficacious of magical operations: for the violent, intentional interruption of the rays a living thing emits must needs impact the material world.) Simply put, al-Kindī here marries the Peripatetic doctrine of causation with Neoplatonic emanationism, thereby allowing astral rays to have physical, magical effects. His protégé then thoroughly developed this theme—this in a way that allowed for the subsequent robust theorization of magic—, and the *Great Introduction* became the central astrological reference work throughout the medieval and early modern Islamo-Christian world. As Lemay has shown, moreover, Abū Maʿsharian astrology was the primary vector by which Aristotelianism as such was introduced to Europe.³

A similar theory informs the Arabic Ps.-Aristotelica, including that corpus's two most seminal texts. The first is the *Secret of Secrets* (*Sirr al-Asrār*), most likely an original Arabic product of the same High Abbasid context, wherein Aristotle emphasizes for the benefit of his student Alexander the crucial importance of astrology, magic, and alchemy for creating and governing a world empire. As the Latin *Secretum secretorum*, this Arabic astral-magical

2. On this theme see e.g. Garth Fowden, *Before and after Muḥammad: The First Millennium Refocused* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014).

3. *Abu Maʿshar and Latin Aristotelianism in the Twelfth Century: The Recovery of Aristotle's Natural Philosophy through Arabic Astrology* (Beirut: American University of Beirut Press, 1962). Where Lemay holds Abū Maʿshar to be a determinist, Saif joins Peter Adamson in deeming him a compatibilist (22–26).

text too enjoyed wide circulation throughout Christendom for centuries. (Roger Bacon was particularly taken with it.) The second is the *Theology of Aristotle* (*Uthūlūjiyā* < *Theologia Aristotelis*), a ninth-century Arabic paraphrase, produced by a member of al-Kindī's circle in Abbasid Iraq, of Plotinus's *Enneads* IV–VI; it ensured that *Neoplatonism* remained at the heart of Christian (and Islamic) philosophy, occult or otherwise, and however Aristotelianizing in tenor.

The name *Picatrix* is synonymous with *magic*. As is well known, this, the most influential grimoire of early modern Christendom, is a thirteenth-century Spanish-cum-Latin translation of the *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm*) of Maslama al-Qurṭubī (d. 964); less well known is the fact that the Andalusī mathematician explicitly and smoothly adapted the above texts as his primary theoretical foundation, presenting astral or talismanic magic as the epitome of applied natural philosophy as a whole. In an important intervention (one representative of others she makes throughout the book), Saif here takes issue with David Pingree's influential analysis of the text in particular, which sharply distinguishes between “high” and “sophisticated” Neoplatonic astral magic and “wretched,” “nauseous,” and “crude” mundane magic, arguing indeed that the former is merely a front for the latter, and is perverted thereby (38). But this is to conflate the *morality* of a given magical practice, questionable or otherwise, with its theoretical basis; yet most subsequent scholars have followed the same tack. An exception is Vittoria Perrone Compagni, who has argued for the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm*'s theoretical unity.⁴ Saif pursues the same argument “to show that semiology, causality and spirituality”—as well as Neoplatonism and Peripateticism—“are reconciled in the *Ghaya*,” which “presents a living universe ordered according to causal relations” (38, 45).

In chapters three and four, Saif takes up the theme of the Arabic-Latin translation movement of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, whereby these Arabic texts—with the addition of, crucially, the *Metaphysics* (*ilāhiyyāt*) of Ibn Sīnā's (d. 1037) philosophical summa *The Cure* (*K. al-Shifā'*)—were adopted as the theoretical basis for a new Neoplatonic-Aristotelian Christian cosmology and natural-philosophical theories of magic, including *medical* magic. Together they constituted, that is, a coherent astrological-magical curriculum that allowed Christian cosmologists of the High Middle Ages to incorporate the heavens into natural philosophy, pivoting on the principle of

4. “*Picatrix*: une philosophie pour la pratique,” in Jean-Patrice Boudet, Anna Cai-ozzo, and Nicolas Weill-Parot, eds., *Images et magie: Picatrix entre orient et occident* (Paris: Honoré Champion, 2011), 359–72.

the universe's intelligibility as an emanated-causal construct. The Western quest to understand "life, the universe and everything" was now joined by western Europeans of the likes of Adelard of Bath (d. 1152), Hermann of Carinthia (d. 1160), Hugh of St. Victor (d. 1141), Thierry of Chartres (d. ca. 1150), Bernard Silvestris (d. 1178), William of Conches (d. ca. 1154), and Daniel of Morley (d. ca. 1210). And following Fārābī (d. 950), whose *Enumeration of the Sciences* (*Iḥṣā' al-ʿUlūm*) was translated twice by Gerard of Cremona (d. 1187) and Dominicus Gundissalinus (d. 1190) respectively, astrology was now received as integral to *physics*.⁵ Before the introduction of Arabic astrological texts, medieval Christian cosmology was primarily Neoplatonic in tenor (the *Timaeus* in particular figured prominently), and posited only a *semiological* relationship between celestial and terrestrial bodies, rejecting, with Plotinus, the principle of astral causality—precisely the principle given Aristotelian form by Abū Maʿshar. (As Saif puts it: "In Plato we find a description, in Abu Maʿshar an explanation" [54].) These twelfth-century Christian cosmologists therefore embraced astral causality and generation as a superior mode for both riddling the cosmos as an intelligible object and defending against accusations of astrolatry, even demonolatry: in Arabic astrology planets need not be gods, *contra* such influential texts as the hermetic *Asclepius* and Cicero's (d. 43 BCE) *De natura deorum*.

This is not to say that the "mystical" Neoplatonic perspective was discarded in favor of a more hardnosed Aristotelian one, but simply that in Latin, as in Arabic, the two were now effectively fused—and fully Christianized. The natural philosophy of the twelfth century boasted an unprecedented "reconciliatory epistemological attitude between the natural and mystical, the revelatory and deductive, the reasoned and the enchanted"; this spirit would similarly animate their heirs, the occult philosophers of the Renaissance (69).

If Latin natural philosophy was systematically astrologized in both etiological and semiological terms in the twelfth century, in the thirteenth its *magical* applications became central to philosophical practice. This shift was furthered by new or fuller translations of Arabic texts on magic—chief among them al-Kindī's *On Rays* and the *Secret of Secrets*, which in the guise of Philip of

5. These translators were unaware of their later contemporary Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī's (d. 1202) unprecedented *mathematicalization* of astrology; following him, subsequent Persian—but not Arabic—encyclopedias of the sciences increasingly elevated astrology from the natural to the mathematical sciences. Significantly, John Dee would only do the same some four centuries later (see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition," *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5 [2017]: 127–99).

Tripoli's *Secretum secretorum* achieved wide circulation in Europe. Significantly, this translation was edited by Roger Bacon in around 1280, and he came to rely heavily thereon in developing his own theory of magic. The *Picatrix* too was a product of the thirteenth century; curiously, it did not enjoy the immediate success of the *Secretum secretorum*, but exploded in popularity in the early modern period. With Abū Ma'shar's *Great Introduction*, then, these Arabic-Latin texts together constituted the primary theoretical platform for European occult philosophy from the thirteenth century onward. Crucially, again, the redefinition of natural magic as astral-psychical allowed Christian sages to sidestep the accusations of demon and planet worship that had earlier stymied such philosophizing.

In support of this narrative, Saif focuses on the Franciscan Roger Bacon (d. 1292), the Dominican Albertus Magnus (d. 1280), and his student Thomas Aquinas (d. 1274). Continuing the project of the divines of Chartres and Paris, this scholastic triumvirate fully assimilated Aristotle by way of Abū Ma'sharian astrology and Avicennan metaphysics, with emphasis on the concept of volitional causality. Ibn Sīnā's *Metaphysics* had been done into Latin (*Liber de philosophia prima sive scientia divina*) by Gundissalinus; significantly, therein the Persian sage and second Aristotle does espouse a theory of astral causation, a fact often ignored in the literature, given his famous hostility to astrology and alchemy; but it is less deterministic than Abū Ma'shar's, and does not award exclusive influence to the celestial realm—terrestrial influences are of equal importance. And he wholly rejects the *semiological* theory of astrology. Avicennan metaphysics, in short, for all its ostensibly anti-occultist stance, provided a solid Aristotelian-Neoplatonic grounding for the theory and practice of astral magic in its Islamic and Christian receptions alike; and Bacon in particular developed it as an independent scholarly genre that fostered a sense of the universe's knowability.

Such was the Arabic-Latin bedrock and birthing ground of the European Renaissance of two centuries later. Now scholarship to date, from Yates onward, has heavily emphasized the *Neoplatonizing* tenor of Renaissance occult philosophy, this as epitomized by its foremost exponents, the sage-mages Marsilio Ficino (d. 1499), Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494), and John Dee (d. 1608). As Saif shows, however, extending the arguments of Paul Oskar Kristeller, Brian Vickers, Richard Kieckhefer, Darrell Rutkin, and Brian Copenhaver, Arabic Aristotelian theories of astral causation remained very much a part of the theory and practice of magic in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. Contemporary self-positioning and polemic aside, that is, the period's intellectual history is as complicated and motley—as

openly contradictory—as the Arabic–Latin traditions it inherited. The Yatesian fiction of a hegemonic Renaissance Hermeticism as evidence for a clean Neoplatonic break with scholastic precedent does not just oversimplify Renaissance occult philosophy, but deforms it entirely: for it divorces Plato from Aristotle and dispenses with the latter in a manner that would have been anathema to all early modern occult philosophers. The “Hermeticism” Yates scried does have some basis in the sources, to be sure—but only as an instance of magical nostalgia, an invocation of the *prisca theologia*, not as concrete philosophical principle; and the perennialist ethos that pervaded Renaissance occultist thought hardly entailed the rejection of scholastic precedent.⁶

Ficino, Pico, and Dee, quite simply, were occult, but not Hermetic, philosophers, and fully conscious of their Arabic debts.⁷ Thus while the Neoplatonizing Ficino was indeed responsible for the landmark Latin translation of the (late) Hellenic *Corpus Hermeticum*, even he remained committed to the Aristotelian principle of astral causation, and emphasized the stars’ role in generating and influencing the human body: hence his assertions as to the superior effectiveness of *physical* applications over imaginal in his discussions on magic, particularly medical magic. Pico, whose humanistic doctrine is in part expressly Arabic,⁸ went farther in the same vein, making it his (brief) life’s work to conclusively and comprehensively marry Plato to Aristotle—and he found he could only do so by means of magic and Hebrew kabbalah. His concordist project culminated in the *Conclusions*, which notorious and censored *magnum opus* put forward in ascending epistemological–ontological order philosophical–theological, magical, and kabbalistic theses, formulated to make possible the theurgic divinization of the human soul (and to use Judaism against itself). Against Chaim Wirszubski and Brian Copenhaver, who define Pico’s magic as wholly kabbalistic, Saif here defends Yates’s distinction between natural magic and “practical Cabala,” the latter focused on

6. Kevin van Bladel (*The Arabic Hermes: From Pagan Sage to Prophet of Science* [Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009]) has shown the nonexistence of a coherent Hermeticism or Hermetism in the Arabic context—we may only speak of Hermes as one mage–prophet among many; the same principle applies to the Latin. Interestingly, as Saif notes, Abū Ma’shar himself was responsible for the invention of “three Hermeses,” and hence the Latin appellation *Trismegistus* (100).

7. As Dee declares in the *Mathematicall Praeface*, discussing his universal mathematical–kabbalistic science of *archemastrie* (London, 1570, sig. A.iiij): “To this Science, doth the *Science Alnirangiat*, great Service.”

8. It is insufficiently marked that his celebrated *Oration* opens precisely with reference to the “Arabs” (126).

harnessing higher spiritual powers “beyond the natural powers of the cosmos.”⁹ That is, the father of Christian kabbalah asserted it to be superior to (Arabic) magic, the supreme mode of metaphysics; and he was followed in this by such early modern Christian sage-mages as Johannes Reuchlin (d. 1522), Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (d. 1535), and John Dee.

Saif takes up the example of the Welsh occult philosopher to conclude her study: for it is in Dee that all the above strands come together into a cohesive, if not monolithic, early modern occult philosophy pivoting on Arabic-Latin astrology and astral magic on the one hand and kabbalah on the other, together constituting a “cabala of the real.” She identifies three main schools of interpretation of his thought and position in Western intellectual history: 1) the positivist, common in the 1950s and 1970s, whereby Dee’s oeuvre is sanitized and reduced to *protoscience*; 2) the Yatesian, common from the 1960s to the present, positing a Neoplatonic-Hermetic-kabbalistic conceptual unity and homogeneity to Dee’s project as herald of the Scientific Revolution and its mathematization of the cosmos; and 3) that of Nicholas Clulee, first formulated in the 1970s, which rejects the assumption of coherence in Dee’s oeuvre and decouples it from later philosophical-scientific developments, instead investigating his debt to medieval scholasticism. Saif here—and indeed in the book as a whole—takes the last approach, emphasizing the neglected but vital Aristotelian-scholastic aspect of Dee’s occultist thought, in faithful emulation of Bacon, Ibn Sīnā, al-Kindī, and Abū Ma’shar.

And here we have thematically come full circle: for as Dee charges us in his infamous *Monas Hieroglyphica*, we must “[raise] towards heaven our cabbalistic eyes” (*Sublevatis ergo in Caelum oculis Cabalisticis*)¹⁰—must simultaneously pursue, in other words, the *hermeneutic* and the *causal* interpretation of nature as scripture, to read the Two Books with two eyes, to marry Plato and Aristotle by means of Arabic astral magic and Hebrew kabbalah in equal measure—with angels on top. This was the central quest of early modern occult philosophy; it must therefore not be gauged *with only one eye*, and that jaundiced by totalitarian modernity.

To this end, Saif keeps both eyes firmly trained on the Arabic-to-Latin tradition as a vital philosophical continuum from the ninth century to the turn of the seventeenth, eschewing any unfavorable comparisons between early modern occult philosophy and modern scientific rationality, on the one hand, à la Keith Thomas, and positivistic or Yatesian teleologies that posit it

9. Francis Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1964), 90.

10. Trans. C. H. Josten, *Ambix* 12 (1964): 84–221, 175.

as protoscience, on the other. Nor does she seek, following Kieckhefer, to rehabilitate occult philosophy by reducing it to a type of “specific rationality”; her project is rather to avoid such reductionism altogether (5). Saif succeeds in that project, providing further, ample evidence—as if any were still needed—that the Victorian vivisectionist science-magic-religion triad has perverted and continues to pervert scholarship on premodern and modern societies alike, rendering it willy-nilly *colonialist*; that triad must therefore finally be retired, including in the intellectual historiography of early modern Christian Europe itself.

While this study succeeds in recolonizing Western intellectual history with the Arabic theories and texts that shaped and sustained it, however, it does not capitalize on this maneuver by further *decolonizing* it: the standard teleological narrative that makes of early modern Christian occult philosophy the *culmination* of Islamic precedent remains implicitly intact, and the account of Arabic-Latin scholarly continuity remains rupturous with respect to early modern Western—Islamo-Christian—occult philosophy as a contiguous whole. To be fair, given the thoroughly colonized, vivisectioned nature of most scholarship on “postclassical” Islamic intellectual history until quite recently, wherein occultism features almost exclusively as low superstition,¹¹ the comparative study of Islamo-Christian occult philosophy is simply *not yet possible*; indeed, the vast majority of the many hundreds of thousands of relevant extant texts have yet to be published, much less studied. And in any event, it is indisputable that the Arabic texts most relevant to intellectual developments in Latin Christendom alone were all produced between the ninth and twelfth centuries, and the great Arabic-Latin translation movement had effectively ceased by the fourteenth (with a short-lived resumption, via Hebrew, in the late fifteenth). (Greek Christendom is another matter.) Nevertheless, I believe it crucial, even at this very early stage of research, to avoid reinscribing the pernicious narrative of Islamo-Christian intellectual divergence, to tirelessly announce it as the artifact of modern colonialist orientalism that it so manifestly is.

Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406) is here a case in point. Saif briefly cites the Tunisian historian—roundly dismissed by his contemporaries but celebrated, not coincidentally, by French colonialists—in support of her observation that Islamic occultism had become largely *Suficized* by the fourteenth century, and so

11. A classic example is Armand Abel, “La place des sciences occultes dans la décadence,” in R. Brunschvig and G. E. von Grunebaum, eds., *Classicism et déclin culturel dans l’histoire de l’Islam* (Paris: Editions Besson Chantemerle, 1957), 291–311.

profoundly divergent from its contemporary Christian heir (29).¹² He would have us believe, that is, that the Muslim occultists-cum-Sufis of his day were abandoning *en masse* the balanced Neoplatonic-Aristotelian synthesis their predecessors first achieved, epitomized by the *Goal of the Sage*, in favor of a purer mysticism; and their new Sufi magic was blatantly *unnatural*, was terminally *Islamic*. Christian occultists-cum-philosophers, on the contrary, having exited the early medieval mystic fog by way of the translation movement, could thus take their place as the primary Western exponents of a natural philosophy predicated on Arabic astral magic.

This impression, put simply, is wildly false: the notoriously ill-informed and reactionary historian is unreliable on this and most matters. He is responsible for the influential misattribution of the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm* to Maslama al-Majrīṭī (d. 1008), for instance, and knows nothing of occult-scientific developments in the persophone east past the twelfth century. Most problematically, Ibn Khaldūn's express project was to have the occult sciences—as well as Avicennan philosophy in general—*outlawed by state fiat*; and the garbled, contradictory, and reductionist arguments he advances to this end are distinctly Augustinian in their fideism. Yet, astonishingly, his unconvincing anti-occultist polemic continues to be taken as evidence for the contemporary marginalization of occult philosophy in the Islamic world.¹³ I contend that it is evidence for precisely the reverse.¹⁴

As the manuscript record makes abundantly clear, an occultist renaissance was sweeping the Islamic heartlands around the turn of the fifteenth century, and there remained a mainstream cultural force through at least the seventeenth, in places even the nineteenth; it is this development that alarmed the

12. Saif has elsewhere written on this Suficization process: "From *Gāyat al-ḥakīm* to *Šams al-ma'ārif*: Ways of Knowing and Paths of Power in Medieval Islam," in Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah D. Gardiner, eds., *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, *Arabica* Supplement Series 1 (Leiden: Brill, 2017). See also Noah D. Gardiner, "Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period" (Ph.D. diss., University of Michigan, 2014).

13. To be clear, this is not Saif's thesis; but while she does note the polemical tenor of Ibn Khaldūn's treatment of magic, natural or Sufi, contrasting it with Ibn al-Nadīm's (d. 990) in particular, her citing of this source alone as representative of late fourteenth-century Islamic developments and emphasis on "mysticism" necessarily imply such a narrative. For an explicit, positivist statement of this thesis see, for example, Ahmad Dallal, *Islam, Science, and the Challenge of History* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010), 144–45.

14. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Defending Geomancy: Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebuts Ibn Khaldūn's Critique of the Occult Sciences," in Melvin-Koushki and Gardiner, eds., *Islamicate Occultism*.

deeply conservative Ibn Khaldūn and inspired his anti-occultist polemic—the last significant such in the premodern Arabic scholarly tradition. After centuries of pitched debate, that is, occultism’s proponents appear to have won, and its opponents to have lost. This renaissance was predicated on the Suficization of occultism in the Islamic west during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, to be sure; but it itself was most characterized by a powerful resurgence of *Neopythagoreanism*, as well as a renewed embrace of astral-natural magic.

This basic fact, advisedly elided by Ibn Khaldūn, is confirmed by another, far more reliable fourteenth-century anti-occultism polemicist: Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya (d. 1350). Railing against the occult sciences on rationalist and traditionalist grounds alike, this conservative Damascene jurist-theologian identified the resurgence of Neopythagorean-Neoplatonic (*fīthāghūrī-aflātūnī*) occult philosophy then beginning as the greatest threat to Islam in the post-Mongol era, together with the continued mainstream status of Avicennan philosophy as a parallel current; he further identified the first as the direct heir of Isma‘ili esotericism, and Ibn Sīnā himself as a self-confessed Isma‘ili heretic. It was precisely Muslim scholars’ embrace of such heretical philosophizing, Ibn al-Qayyim charged, that called down the catastrophic Mongol conquest in the first place.¹⁵

The hostility of this intellectual historiography aside, the vast network of scholars responsible for the occultist renaissance in question—a veritable republic of letters extending from Anatolia and Egypt to Transoxania and India—found it perfectly accurate, and embraced such smears as a point of pride. In particular, and partly by way of polemical retort, they styled themselves the *New Brethren of Purity*, thereby broadcasting their intent to revive and expand the occult-philosophical project of the original Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafāʾ*) of tenth-century Abbasid Iraq—the shadowy semi-Isma‘ili and wholly Neopythagorean group of encyclopedists that appears to have claimed Maslama al-Qurṭubī himself as a member.¹⁶ Unlike the original Brethren, however, their early fifteenth-century Sunni heirs seized on *lettrism*,

15. Ibid.

16. See e.g. Cornell Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries,” in Massumeh Farhad and Serpil Bağcı, eds., *Falnama: The Book of Omens* (London: Thames, 2009), 232–43, 329–30; Godefroid de Callataÿ, “Magia en al-Andalus: *Rasāʾil Ijwān al-Ṣafāʾ*, *Rutbat al-ḥakīm* y *Gāyat al-ḥakīm* (Picatrix),” *al-Qanṭara* 34 (2013): 297–344. Echoing Ibn al-Qayyim, Fowden identifies the Brethren of Purity and Ibn Sīnā in particular as the West’s greatest heirs and synthesizers of the late antique philosophical heritage (*Before and after Muḥammad*, 205–7).

kabbalah's coeval Arabic cognate, as the primary vehicle for a new brand of Neopythagorean-Neoplatonic occult philosophy encompassing and transcending Peripateticism, Illuminationism and Sufism. Emphatically perennialist and universalist, this philosophy asserted *letter-number* to be the supreme object of metaphysics and magic in equal measure, the *coincidentia oppositorum* marrying Plato and Aristotle by means of a semiticized Pythagoras.¹⁷

A virtually identical development, as we have seen, defined the occult philosophy of that other Renaissance, particularly that of Pico and Dee; but it began in Europe decades later, and in the absence of direct contact. We must therefore no longer assume a permanent early modern occult-philosophical Islamo-Christian divergence, this by invoking the hugely problematic category of "mysticism" or relying on anti-occultist polemics, but rather a *reconvergence*. Given that the primary node of that reconvergence was a renaissance of Neopythagoreanism, moreover, to disappear this distinct intellectual current from early modern Western occult philosophy, as Saif's study does, must needs reinforce the false impression of intellectual divergence. The fifteenth-century Western world was rather witness to an astonishing occult-philosophical convergence; equally astonishing is the fact that this convergence has been and is still totally elided in the literature.

That is not to say that this early modern Islamo-Christian convergence was total; to the contrary, it was primarily theoretical in nature. Constrained by very different sociopolitical structures, philosophical *praxis* in Islamdom and Christendom remained rather sharply divergent. It cannot be overemphasized that the early modern Islamic world was far vaster, wealthier, and more cosmopolitan than its Christian counterpart, relatively isolated as the latter was in the far west of the Afro-Eurasian ecumene; and it is only in the former that the *occult-scientific universalist imperialism* propounded in such seminal Arabic-Latin texts as Ps.-Aristotle's *Secret of Secrets* was actually politically realized.¹⁸ That is to say, the occult philosophers of the early modern Islamic

17. I have elsewhere shown the *coincidentia oppositorum* to be the central theme of Islamic occult philosophy in general and lettrism in particular from the early fifteenth century onward ("Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka's Lettrist Metaphysics of Light," *al-ʿUṣṭūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 [2016]: 46–117). That the same is true of the Christian context—the Latin term was coined, significantly, by Nicholas of Cusa (d. 1464)—suggests it as a major node for comparative study (see e.g. David Albertson, *Mathematical Theologies: Nicholas of Cusa and the Legacy of Thierry of Chartres* [Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014]).

18. On this comparative theme see my forthcoming *The Occult Science of Empire in Aqquyunlu-Safavid Iran*.

world consciously embodied the Neoplatonic notion of sage (*ḥakīm*) as *occult-ist architect of the world*, theurgic invoker of the celestial and the divine through practices expressly magical in order to understand—and shape—reality.¹⁹ The proof of the pudding, as always, is in the eating: can it be considered mere coincidence that the Islamic imperiums this host of sage-mage builders and protectors of society so faithfully served (the Timurid, Mughal, and Ottoman in particular) became the greatest of the early modern era?

Ficino, Pico, and Dee thus nowise lacked intellectual peers in Islamdom. To the contrary: for all their express reliance on the epochal Arabic (occult-) philosophical synthesis, *they were not its most immediate or indeed even greatest heirs*, and wielded considerably less political and social influence than the Neopythagoreanizing New Brethren of Purity, their contemporary Muslim cognates to the south and east. Not that “greatness,” however construed, should be the primary criterion; but the jury is certainly still out, and a colonialist-orientalist double standard still firmly in place.

The occult philosophy peculiar to the early modern Western world, in sum, was pursued throughout the Afro-Eurasian ecumene more often—and to greater sociopolitical effect—in Arabic and Persian than in Latin and English. That the bulk of the former was not done into the latter is of relevance only for a teleological historiography. The brute fact of this wild imbalance in the literature hardly invalidates studies such as Saif’s; but the straitness and peculiarity of the western Christian model, which terminally (albeit pragmatically) excludes most of the ocean of relevant textual data, puts hard limits on the scholarly claims that can currently be made as to the nature of early modern Western intellectual history in general and occult philosophy in particular. Saif therefore does well to assert precisely these limits, to temporally and geographically quarantine her subject against occultophobic, Islamophobic, and Yatesian colonizations alike, to recolonize Latin with Arabic.

The task now is to pursue a comparative early modern Western intellectual history worth the name; and *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy* provides a solid basis for just this pursuit.²⁰ Saif’s concluding call to

19. See Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran,” in Sajjad Rizvi, ed., *Philosophy and the Intellectual Life in Shīʿī Islam* (London: Bloomsbury, 2017).

20. Under the aegis of the Warburg Institute, Saif is currently working on a full edition and English translation of the Arabic *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm*—amazingly, the only English translations made to date of this most famous of grimoires are based on inferior editions of the Latin *Picatrix*—, as well as a large-scale project on the Arabic *Hermetica*, both of which will help make possible, finally, a comparative early modern Western intellectual history. On the level of popular culture, moreover, Saif is also a member of the project “Magic in Malta, 1605,” led by Dionysius Agius and

reenchant the world (199), moreover, is to be heeded as a moral duty most pressing, an act of decolonization, an erasure of violent lines in the sand: for here as elsewhere, Islam remains the colonized-orientalized Other, the *occult West*.²¹ It seems a historical justice, then, that the high Christian occultism of the Renaissance remained so profoundly and organically—if occultly—*Islamic*.

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21. Cf. Wouter Hanegraaff's argument for esotericism as the primary Other upon whose undead frame Western modernity has been and continues to be constructed (*Esotericism and the Academy: Rejected Knowledge in Western Culture* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012].) I suggest that the same obtains for Islam in general and early modern Islamic occultism in particular. For the latter is the modern West's *Triply Other*; its study is therefore an especially efficient means of exploding (auto)colonialist modernity.

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